

Performance Audit

June 2022

Durham Emergency Communications Center

911 Staffing



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Audit Services Department
City of Durham, North Carolina



Date: June 13, 2022
To: Audit Services Oversight Committee
From: Germaine Brewington, Director of Audit Services
Subject: 911 Staffing Performance Audit

The Audit Services Department staff completed the report for the 911 Staffing Performance Audit dated June 2022. The purposes of this audit were to: 1) determine if DECC is meeting its goal to provide timely emergency call processing; 2) review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain adequate staffing levels; and 3) review the training program.

This report presents the observations and results of the 911 Staffing Performance Audit. Six (6) recommendations were proposed. In response to these audit recommendations, City Management concur with the recommendations made. The detailed Management Response to the recommendations is included with the attached report.

The Audit Services Department staff would like to acknowledge the contributions of staff from the Durham Emergency Communications Department and the Department of Human Resources for providing information to enable the audit process.



Durham Emergency Communications Center

June 2022

Objectives

The Objectives of the audit were to:

1. determine if DECC is meeting its goal to provide timely emergency call processing;
2. review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain adequate staffing levels; and
3. review the training program.

Background

The Durham Emergency Communications Center (DECC) is the primary public safety answering point (PSAP) for the City and County of Durham. Guided by the City's Strategic Plan, the center helps to ensure that Durham is a safe and secure community by providing around-the-clock 911 access and services to the residents and user agencies in and around Durham County. The geographic service area encompasses 296 square miles with approximately 326,126 residents.

REPORT HIGHLIGHTS

DECC staff have made efforts to increase hiring.

DECC staff have improved their recruiting efforts and also increased their training capacity. These changes have resulted in the Department being able to hire more employees.

Approximately 52 employees were hired in FY 2022.

Now training classes can accommodate up to 12 employees. In addition, the goal is to have four training academies a year. Additional training staff were hired to support expanded capacity in the training academies.

WHY THIS AUDIT IS IMPORTANT

Lives can be put at risk if communications center staffing is not adequate. Given recent staffing challenges that all PSAPs are facing nationwide, it was important to ensure DECC is prioritizing monitoring of its staffing and making adjustments as quickly as feasible to provide the best service to its residents.

DECC staff are aware that they should:

- 1) Address high turnover rates
- 2) Utilize a staffing model used by the industry to establish minimum staffing levels
- 3) Revisit the possibility of alternate staffing schedules
- 4) Reexamine the organizational structure of the Training Division to make the Division more efficient and effective.

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BACKGROUND

*Durham
Emergency
Communications
is the primary
public safety
answering point
(PSAP) for the City.*

There is a staffing crisis in Emergency Communications centers all across the country. Public Safety Answering Points (PSAPs) across the nation are chronically understaffed, leading to a workforce that is continually stressed, overworked, and burned out. New hires and trainees are frequently gone before their probationary periods end. High performers move to other companies for better pay and career advancement opportunities. The workplace challenges brought to light by the global pandemic present various concerns that must be examined and addressed.

The Durham Emergency Communications Center (DECC) is the primary public safety answering point for the City and County of Durham. Guided by the City's Strategic Plan, the Center helps to ensure that Durham is a safe and secure community by providing around-the-clock 911 access and services to the residents and user agencies in and around Durham County. The geographic service area encompasses 296 square miles with approximately 326,126 residents.

In 2021, callers experienced delays in having their calls answered. In response, DECC management stated that they were working hard to provide the prompt service residents rightfully expect. DECC management outlined steps that would help enhance staffing in order to provide better service. The Audit Services Department staff wanted to examine the corrective action efforts implemented by DECC.

The DECC provides 24 hour-a-day, 7 days-a-week 911 access and services to the residents and user agencies in and around Durham County. Services provided include, but are not limited to:

- Dispatch of police, fire, emergency medical services
- Emergency and non-emergency request for services
- Other City/County support agencies

911 Call Taking

The DECC is the PSAP for all of Durham County. Each 911 call comes directly to the center and is handled according to its location and nature. During the call, the 911 Communications Officer ascertains, at a minimum, the location and nature of the emergency. Other information obtained includes, but is not limited to:

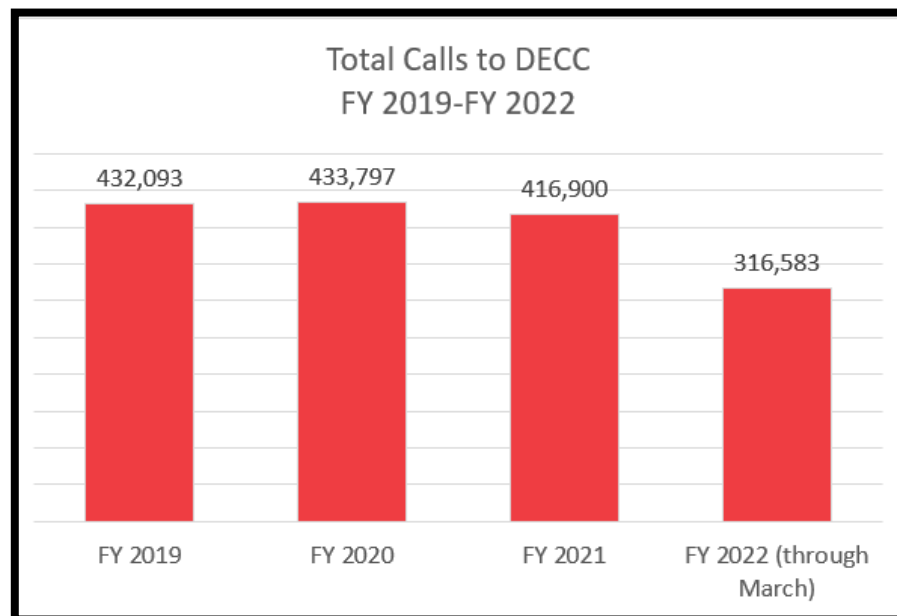
- The caller's name, address and call-back number
- Certain information for medical calls (nature, life status, etc.)
- Descriptions of suspects / victims
- Potential hazards
- The presence of any weapons (if applicable)

When each 911 call is received, the phone number and location of the caller is displayed at the console and verified by the 911 Communications Officer. This information is kept in strictest confidence and released only to emergency services personnel.

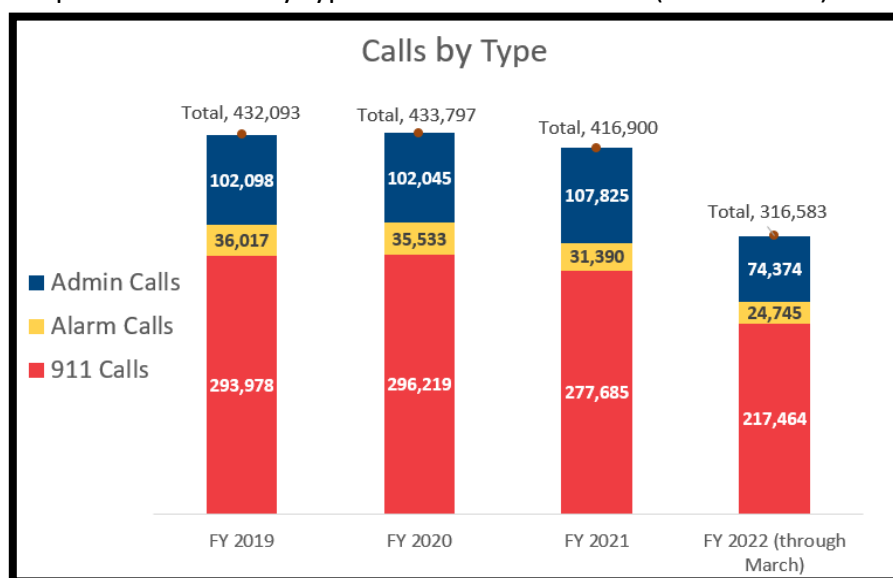
Call statistics

Call statistics are displayed in Graph 1 and Graph 2 below.

Graph 1. Total calls to DECC in FY 2019 to FY 2022 (March 2022)



Graph 2. Total calls by type in FY 2019 to FY 2022 (March 2022)

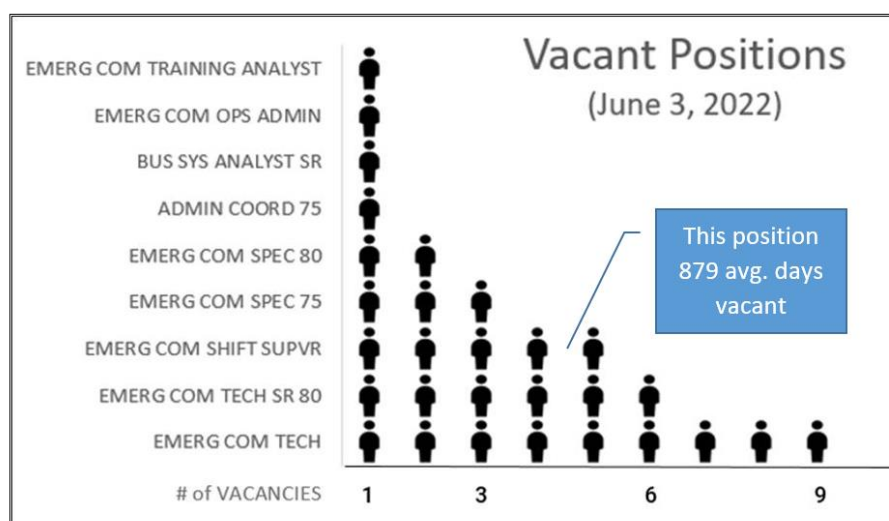


DECC authorized positions

The DECC has 84 authorized positions. On June 3, 2022, 34.5 percent of the positions were vacant. Figure 1 (below) shows the authorized positions compared to vacancies in the Department, as well as the number of vacancies per position.

Figure 1: DECC authorized positions versus vacancies

DEPARTMENT	POSITIONS	# of VACANCIES	% VACANT	AVG. LENGTH OF VACANCY
Emergency Communications	84	29	34.5%	242 days



Per DECC management, currently there are five vacant Shift Supervisor positions. They have utilized an employee to serve as Acting Shift Supervisor since July 2021 and are currently recruiting for two of the five positions.

The number of days that positions in DECC were vacant ranged from approximately 0 to 879, with the Emergency Communications Shift Supervisor position being vacant for the most number of days – 879 days on average.

Systems Used

Currently The Durham Emergency Communications Center is equipped with some of the most modern and technologically advanced equipment systems on the market. DECC utilizes the Next Generation 911 (NG911) systems as well as automated computer voice dispatching of Fire and EMS units.

OBJECTIVES

The objectives of the audit were to:

- determine if DECC is meeting its goal to provide timely emergency call processing;
- review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain adequate staffing levels; and
- review the training program.

FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

DECC has made efforts to increase staffing levels.

Being adequately staffed is key to running a successful emergency communications center. DECC has 84 authorized positions of which 29 were vacant as of June 3, 2022. Results of a research study show that when centers are fully staffed higher retention rates exist. Also more employees are satisfied, and employees work less overtime hours. The list below shows the RETAINS Research Results (Taylor, Gardner, Clark, McCombs, 2005).

Reference

Taylor, M., Gardner, V., Clark, P., McCombs, B. (2005). *Staffing and retention in public safety communication centers*. Project RETAINS: Department of Justice.

Characteristics of Fully Staffed Centers:

- *Had higher retention rates (#1 predictor of center retention rate)*
- *Had more employees who were satisfied*
- *Had employees who worked less overtime hours*
- *Had employees who handled fewer calls per year*
- *Had higher percentage of staff who were fully trained and working independently*

Audit Staff verified DECC efforts to increase staffing levels. DECC staff:

Increased the size and frequency of academies enabling more hiring to occur

DECC cannot hire more employees than it can train at any given time. Employees have to pass the training academy before they can work independently in the 911 center. Prior to this fiscal year, an academy was limited to training only four employees. This training level was creating a bottle neck to increasing staffing levels.

DECC cannot hire more employees than it can train.

DECC provides highly specialized training to new employees through its Training Division. Each employee that is hired has to obtain classroom training as well as practical, On-The-Job training before being released to function independently as a 911 Communications Officer. They also have to meet proficiency standards before being released from training and transitioning to independent work. This training process takes approximately eight to ten weeks. In order to ramp up its hiring efforts, the Department has increased its training capacity. Now training classes can accommodate up to 12 employees. In addition, the goal is to have four (4) training academies a year. Additional training staff were hired to support expanded capacity in the call taker academies.

Improved recruiting efforts

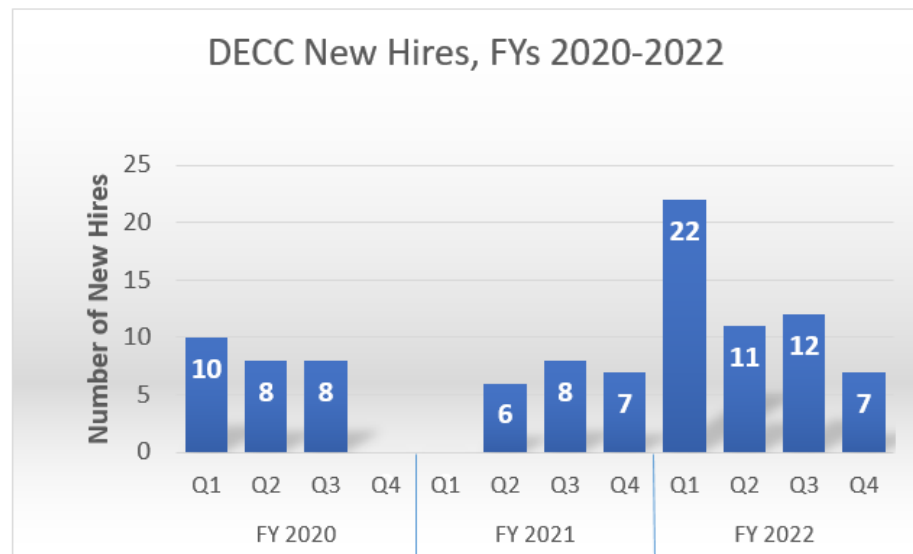
DECC has been creative with how they advertise the available jobs to attract talent and also with how they keep and retain talent. When it comes to advertising, DECC has held job fairs. Recruitment efforts have included bringing back former DECC employees and retirees; bringing in employees from other agencies; and open recruitment using websites, professional organizations, social media, etc. The Department leadership is also looking to create information sessions via Zoom for people to learn and gain a better understanding of the job. In addition, a hiring bonus has been approved to incentivize external candidates and internal City staff who want to advance their careers in the DECC.

The City of Durham has collaborated with Durham Technical Community College to provide course development and financial support in creating a 911 Academy. This effort has the potential to increase the applicant pool of trained emergency communications personnel. These applicants would still need to go through DECC training.

Results of efforts to increase staffing levels

Audit Services staff reviewed hiring data to determine if the efforts implemented by DECC staff were working. Based on data provided by the Human Resources Department staff, hiring significantly increased in FY 2022. See Graph 3 below for data for fiscal years 2020-2022.

Graph 3: New hires by fiscal year quarters



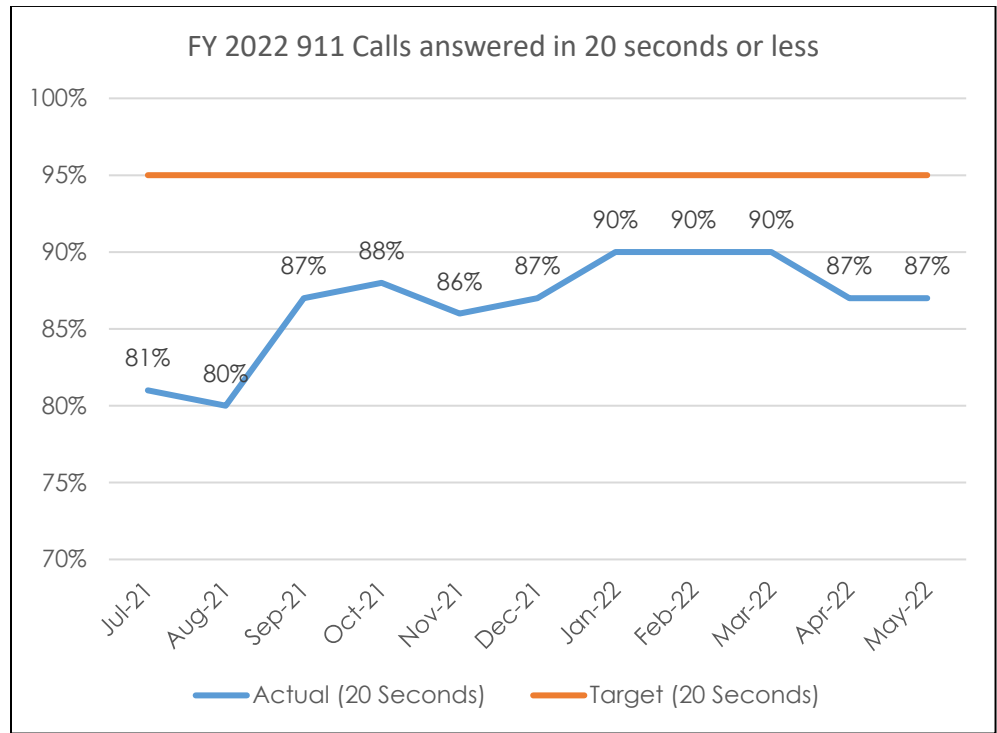
Approximately 52 employees were hired in FY 2022. Hiring levels were lower in FY 2020 and FY 2021, as a result of the impact of the pandemic on DECC operations. No classes were scheduled due to limited training and resources.

Finding 1. DECC has improved 911 call answering times since the start of FY 2022.

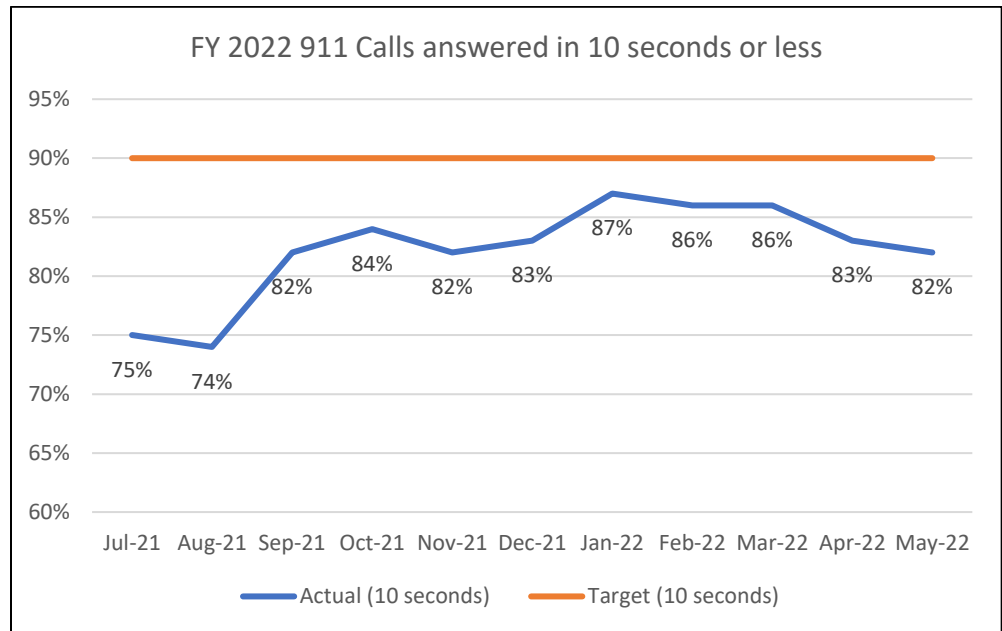
The current performance measures track whether calls received by DECC staff are answered 90% of the time within 10 seconds or 95% of the time within 20 seconds. The NC 911 Board requires that PSAPs answer 90% of 911 calls within 10 seconds or less. Abandoned 911 calls are also included in this data. Graphs 4

and 5 (below) show the answering times for FY 2022 up to May 2022. The FY 2022 911 calls answered in 20 seconds or less have improved since July 2021.

Graph 4: 911 Calls answered within 20 seconds or less



Graph 5: 911 Calls answered within 10 seconds or less



The calls answered within 10 seconds or less have also improved since July 2021.

Recommendation 1: The DECC should continue its efforts to ensure that the performance measures around 911 answer times are met.

Value Added: Risk Reduction, Efficiency

DEPARTMENTAL RESPONSE: MANAGEMENT CONCURS

IMPLEMENTATION DATE: SEPTEMBER 2022

SEE PAGE 22 FOR DEPARTMENT'S FULL RESPONSE.

Finding 2. The turnover rate is high.

DECC positions are inherently stressful and not everyone is equipped to handle the pressures that these jobs create. In this industry, turnover rates are characteristically high; however, a continuously increasing turnover rate might indicate other underlying issues within DECC that might need to be addressed.

The Human Resources Department staff track turnover rates for all City Departments. Based on information provided by the Human Resources staff, the 12-month turnover rate in DECC by fiscal year quarter increased from FY 20 Q4 to now. The FY 22 Q4 as of May 22, 2022 was 64.7%, which captures a lookback from the same time last fiscal year to the present. See Figure 2 below.

Figure 2: DECC turnover rate by quarter



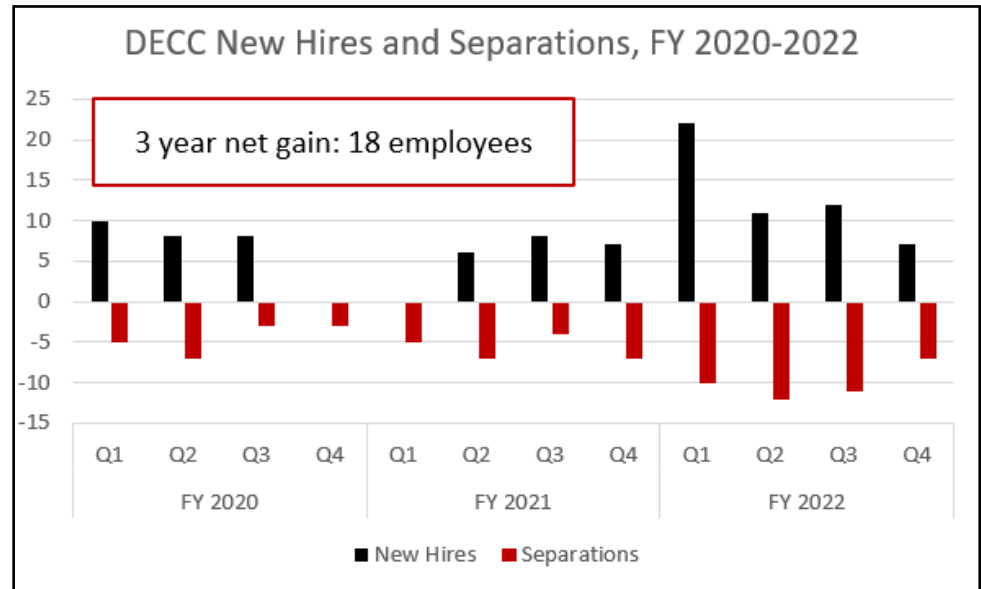
The National Emergency Number Association (NENA) does not collect information on vacancies or turn-over rates within 911 centers; however, they do report, from time to time, what other jurisdictions are reporting. The only statistics available for comparative purposes were in an article published in 2021 that referenced turnover rates. Per the article, “The [National Emergency](#)

DECC's turnover rate is high.

[Number Association](#) reports that nationally, emergency dispatch centers are seeing 15-20% employee turnover.”¹

If DECC cannot retain employees, this condition will undermine their hiring efforts. As seen in Graph 6 below, new hires for the period FY 2020 to FY 2022 were 99; however, 81 employees left the City over that same period.

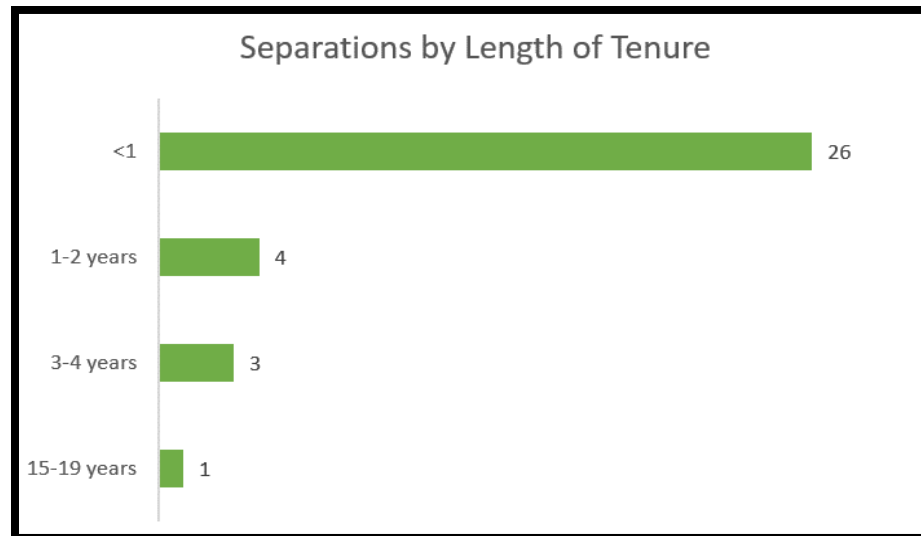
Graph 6. New hires and separations in DECC- FYs 2020-2022



Employees can separate from the City for reasons such as discharge, resignation, retirement etc. About 76% of DECC employees that separated from the City in FY 2022 were employed by the City for less than one year as shown in Graph 7 below.

¹ Courtney, W. (2021). Emergency dispatch centers facing labor shortage. Retrieved from: <https://spectrumlocalnews.com/nc/charlotte/news/2021/10/04/emergency-dispatch-centers-facing-labor-shortage>.

Graph 7. FY 2022 full-time employee separations by tenure



Determining root causes for separations is a good practice to address turnover.

The Director conducts exit interviews on staff who are willing. However, per the Director, that interview data is not documented often at the request of the employee.

Exit interviews/surveys are also conducted by the Human Resources Department staff; however, the surveys/interviews are voluntary. Currently this information from the Human Resources Department is not shared with DECC staff. Audit Services staff reviewed exit survey data for FYs 2020, 2021, and 2022. A total of 26 employees in DECC completed that survey during that time period.

Audit Services staff reviewed the exit interviews. Of the exit interviews conducted and documented, survey respondents gave the reasons below:

- 31% left the City for better job- career advancement
- 27% left the City for high stress/excessive workload/poor work life balance
- 50% were dissatisfied or very dissatisfied with training opportunities within DECC

Continually checking with employees who stay in DECC is also a good tool to address turnover. Employee Satisfaction Surveys (ESS) can provide insight into areas that could cause employees to leave. Addressing those concerns could aid in decreasing turnover rates. The City administered an Employee Satisfaction Survey in FY 2021. DECC is currently working on several issues identified in that Employee Satisfaction Survey including determining whether separations occur prior to or after being fully released from training.

Recommendation 2: The DECC Department staff should, in collaboration with the Human Resources staff, work to reduce turnover rates. DECC staff should perform root cause analysis and address issues identified if feasible. The DECC Department staff should also perform internal studies (surveys, focus groups) to understand why employees choose to stay.

Value Added: Risk Reduction, Efficiency

DEPARTMENTAL RESPONSE: MANAGEMENT CONCURS

IMPLEMENTATION DATE: JULY 1, 2022

SEE PAGE 22 FOR DEPARTMENT'S FULL RESPONSE

Recommendation 3: The Human Resources Department staff should make exit surveys mandatory for employees who separate from DECC. Data from exit interviews should be shared with DECC staff to understand the reasons for separation.

Value Added: Risk Reduction, Efficiency

DEPARTMENTAL RESPONSE: MANAGEMENT CONCURS

IMPLEMENTATION DATE: IMMEDIATELY

SEE PAGE 21 FOR DEPARTMENT'S FULL RESPONSE

Finding 3. Minimum staffing levels per shift were not derived using a systematic formula.

In September of 2021, DECC updated the Minimum Staffing Special Order governing minimum staffing for the DECC. Per this Special Order— Operations Minimum Staffing is defined as:

- Between 07:00 a.m. and 3:00 a.m. – 5 personnel on duty
- Between 3:00 a.m. and 7:00 a.m. – 4 personnel on duty

The Special Order also outlines steps to take as soon as the staffing levels fall below the minimum defined targets. Per DECC management, the minimum staffing levels were derived using daily call volume and the number of operational employees that were employed at the time. A systematic, formula-based process for determining staffing levels was not used. There currently are no national standards requirements around minimum staffing levels.

Overall, DECC was able to maintain minimum staffing levels.

Audit Services staff verified the staffing levels from January 2022 to May 2022 to determine if DECC was able to maintain the minimum staffing levels. Overall, DECC was able to maintain minimum staffing levels during the period of January 2022 to May 2022 with a few exceptions.

Staffing level data provided to the Audit staff captured staffing levels in thirty minute increments per day (See Table 1 below). Audit staff account for each thirty-minute time slot as a shift. See footnotes for a calculation example.

Table 1. Operational staffing levels for January 2022 to May 2022

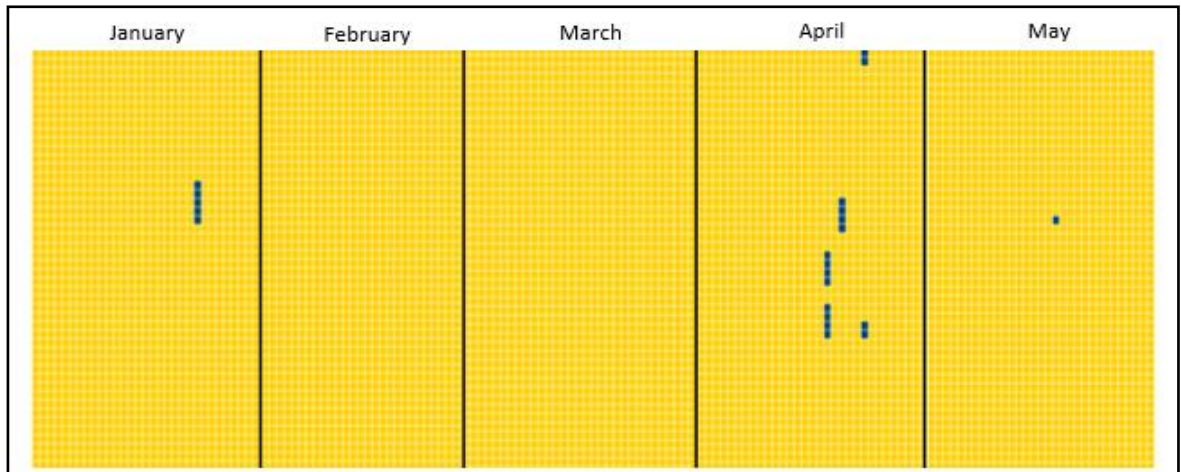
	January (31 days)	February (28 days)	March (31 days)	April (30 days)	May (31 days)
Total shifts²	1,488	1,344	1,488	1,440	1,488
Shifts at or above minimum³	1,483	1,344	1,488	1,424	1,487
Shifts below minimum	5	0	0	16	1
% at or above minimum	99.7%	100%	100%	98.8%	99%

Figure 3 (below) graphically displays the data found in Table 1. The Figure allows the reader to see exactly when shortages occurred and for how long. In January for example, the 31 days of the month are reflected by the boxes going horizontal from left to right. **Yellow** represents half hour shifts at or above minimums; **blue** represents half hour shifts below minimum levels.

² Total shifts=number of 30-minute shifts per day * number of days per month, e.g. January = 2*24(hours)*31(days)=1,488 shifts

³ From 3 a.m.-7 a.m. ≥4; 7 a.m.-3 a.m. ≥5

Figure 3. Graphical presentation of Table 1



For the month of January, there were only five out of 1,488 thirty-minute time slots where the levels were below the minimum established per the DECC Special Order.

Senior City management tracked vacancy data and staffing levels to understand the staffing issue in the Communications Center. The City Manager's Office staff created a dashboard that analyzed the number of agents answering calls against the actual agents needed to answer calls. The Erlang calculation was used to determine how much call center staffing would be needed per hour. The Erlang calculation formula is a mathematical equation for calculating the number of agents needed in a call center, given the number of calls and the service level desired. The dashboard also tracked DECC's staffing and vacancy levels for the period of August 2021 to March 2022.

Per DECC management, the goal is to use the dashboard, along with APCO Retains, another staffing model used across the public safety telecommunications industry to determine minimum staffing levels. Per DECC management, another goal is to increase the minimum staffing levels, as the current established minimum staffing levels are quite low for a center of DECC's size and call volume. Effective practices related to staffing suggest that centers should use staffing tools to estimate the number of employees the center actually needs to handle the workload. Staff should also continually monitor the adequacy of authorized staffing levels.

Recommendation 4: The DECC should utilize a staffing model used by the industry to establish minimum staffing levels and work towards staffing to the established levels. In addition, they should continually monitor the adequacy of the staffing levels.

Value Added: Risk Reduction; Efficiency

**DEPARTMENTAL RESPONSE: MANAGEMENT CONCURS WITH
RESERVATIONS**

IMPLEMENTATION DATE: JULY 1, 2022

SEE [PAGE 23](#) FOR DEPARTMENT'S FULL RESPONSE

Finding 4. The shift schedule was last reviewed in 2020; however, no changes were implemented.

The DECC performed a schedule analysis in 2020. They compared 12- hour shifts versus 10-hour shifts. Based on their analysis, twelve hour schedules would provide improved efficiency of staffing coverage. Management recognizes that a review of the schedule is necessary. According to the effective practices guide, "Shift work is a fact of life in public safety communications centers and effective management of the shift assignment process is directly related to employee satisfaction." Management should determine if the existing shift assignment process is the most effective for Durham at this time and investigate other options, if practical, given current staffing capacity.

Recommendation 5: The DECC staff should revisit the possibility of alternate staffing schedules to see if better efficacy can be achieved.

Value Added: Risk Reduction; Efficiency

AGENCY RESPONSE: MANAGEMENT CONCURS

IMPLEMENTATION DATE: Q2 FY 2023

SEE [PAGE 23](#) FOR AGENCY'S FULL RESPONSE

Finding 5. Risk exists that recent turnover in trainers may affect DECC's training efforts. DECC has established a plan to mitigate this risk.

Per DECC's FY 2022 organization chart, a total of six positions are allocated to training: two full time Training Analysts and four Training Officers. Currently DECC has one full time Training Analyst, one full-time Training Officer and two part-time Training Officer positions filled.

At the start of field work, DECC had two Training Analyst positions filled. One Training Analyst was reassigned out of the Training Division during this time. In

addition, some turnover also occurred in the Training Officer positions. Insufficient trainers in the classroom and on the floor impacts DECC's ability to accomplish its training goals. DECC cannot hire more employees than it can train at any given time. Employees have to pass the training academy before they can work independently in the 911 center.

Per DECC management, "After the resignation of one Certified Training Officer (CTO) on April 28th, the following plan was put into place to ease the impact of that loss to trainees or Training Division team members. The termination of the second CTO on May 17th further escalated the need to have a pivot plan. The loss of the Training Analyst currently has had little impact thus far. Trainees in the current academy will be assigned to mentors and will follow their mentor's shift schedule until released from training. One advanced trainee will begin On-The-Job training on June 6, 2022 with a Mentor. Six trainees will begin On-The-Job training (OJT) with mentors and two (2) Training Division team members on June 21, 2022. One part-time Training Analyst and one CTO will continue with current trainees in the On-The-Job Training phase".

Structurally, the reporting chain per the organization chart shows that the Training Officers report to the Training Analyst. However, at present the Training Officers and the Training Analyst report to the Assistant Director. The Assistant Director is currently performing oversight of the entire training function. This practice is not optimal.

Recommendation 6: The DECC staff should continue their efforts to ensure sufficient trainers are onboard to implement their training plan. They should reexamine the organization structure of the Training Division to make the Division more efficient and effective.

Value Added: Risk Reduction; Efficiency

AGENCY RESPONSE: MANAGEMENT CONCURS.

IMPLEMENTATION DATE: JULY 1, 2022

SEE PAGE 23 FOR DEPARTMENT'S FULL RESPONSE

Value Added Legend



To learn more, visit our website at durhamNC.gov/audit

DEPARTMENTAL RESPONSE TO AUDIT RECOMMENDATIONS



Memo

Date: June 8, 2022
To: Dr. Germaine F. Brewington, Audit Services Director
From: John Scott, Interim Director, Human Resources Department
Subject: Management's Response to Recommendations
911 Staffing Performance Audit

The following is the management's response to the 911 Staffing Performance Audit dated June 13, 2022.

Recommendation 3: The Human Resources Department staff should make exit surveys mandatory for employees who separate from DECC. Data from exit interviews should be shared with DECC staff to understand the reasons for separation.

Departmental Response: We concur. Completion of the exit survey is currently part of the employee separation checklist for all employees and is considered mandatory. However, enforcement options are limited with departing employees. Human Resources will send an additional reminder to employees who have not completed their exit survey in an effort to boost completion rates. Data will be shared with DECC staff on a quarterly basis.

Date: June 8, 2022
To: Dr. Germaine F. Brewington, Audit Services Director
From: Randy Beeman, Durham Emergency Communications Center Director
Subject: Management's Response to Recommendations
911 Staffing Performance Audit

The following is the management's response to the 911 Staffing Performance Audit dated June 13, 2022.

Recommendation 1: The DECC should continue its efforts to ensure that the performance measures around 911 answer times are met.

Departmental Response: We concur. Management is in full agreement with the recommendation and implemented changes to address this effective September 2021.

To ensure 911 answer times are met DECC will:

- Transition trainees that have met certain criteria to answer live calls under the supervision of their trainer. This effort will count towards staffing and allow for improved call answer times.
- Trainers will be utilized as Call Takers as needed.
- Credentialed administrative staff are used as needed to assist in operational functions.

Recommendation 2: The DECC Department staff should, in collaboration with the Human Resources staff, work to reduce turnover rates. DECC staff should perform root cause analysis and address issues identified if feasible. The DECC Department staff should also perform internal studies (surveys, focus groups) to understand why employees choose to stay.

Departmental Response: We concur. Management is in full agreement with the recommendation. Implementation Date: July 1, 2022.

- DECC will track each level in the onboarding life-cycle in which employees are being terminated or resigning. DECC will continue to work with HR to enhance our recruitment and retention efforts. We will also work with our pre-employment vendors to ensure we are utilizing vetted industry specific systems to ensure we are gaging the most qualified candidates. This information can also be used in developing a root cause analysis.
- DECC worked with Talent Keepers to develop a Quarterly Engagement Survey. The initial survey was sent out March 2022. The survey should provide insight on engaging and retaining current employees. The next survey will be administered in July 2022.
- DECC has involved employees to address retention with the Think Tank. The DECC

Think Tank is comprised of DECC team members of all knowledge and skills levels to revamp the foundation of the training division and training practices. This group meets quarterly; preferably before or after a new academy starts. They are encouraged to present ideas, questions, concerns, suggestions and feedback for all training and policy updates. These ideas have been presented to DECC leadership for review.

Recommendation 4: The DECC should utilize a staffing model they deem appropriate to establish minimum staffing levels and work towards staffing to the established levels. In addition, they should continually monitor the adequacy of the staffing levels.

Departmental Response: We concur with reservations. Management is in agreement with the recommendation, but there are circumstances that could affect its implementation which have to be resolved. Implementation Date: 7/1/2022

- In order to increase our efforts, we will utilize the public safety staffing and retention toolkit; APCO Project RETAINS, to assist in establishing our staffing needs.

Recommendation 5: The DECC staff should revisit the possibility of alternate staffing schedules to see if better efficacy can be achieved.

Departmental Response: We concur. Management is in full agreement with the recommendation. Implementation Date: July 2022 for schedule implementation in Q 2 FY23.

- DECC will work with HR, Audit and Finance to revisit the recommended schedule change that was submitted in 2020.

Recommendation 6: The DECC should continue their efforts to ensure sufficient trainers are onboard to implement their training plan. They should reexamine the organization structure of the training division to make the division more efficient and effective.

Departmental Response: We concur. Management is in full agreement with the recommendation. Implementation Date: July 1, 2022.

- Training will not be impacted with the current vacancies in the training division. Current trainees in Academy 2022-B, will be assigned to Mentors and will follow their Mentor's shift schedule until released from training. Mentors range from current Call Takers (1) and Communications Officers (4). DECC is currently in the hiring phase for (3) Trainers and anticipate onboarding in July to assist with training efforts in August. The Training Analyst will be posted within a week with an anticipated start date of July as well. Master Communications Officers and Shift Supervisors will also assist with cross-training efforts to provide more operations capabilities and promote internal growth opportunities. DECC also utilizes 2 part-time Training Analyst to assist in the training division. DECC will be conducting a reorganization of the department that will include a Training Manager. This was requested in FY23 but was not approved. More data will be submitted in FY24 to support this initiative.

SCOPE, METHODOLOGY, and COMPLIANCE

Scope

The scope of the audit included examining current practices related to staffing, training and reviewing performance metrics.

Methodology

Audit Services Department staff performed the following procedures to accomplish the objectives of the audit. Staff:

- Interviewed DECC staff;
- Interviewed Human Resources Department staff that help DECC with staffing;
- Reviewed the performance metrics adopted by the DECC and verified if they align with regulation requirements;
- Reviewed calculation of performance metrics;
- Obtained the performance metrics for FY 2022, FY 2021 and FY 2020 to determine if set targets were met;
- Obtained call data for FY 2022, FY 2021 and FY 2020 and analyzed call data by type of call;
- Obtained total calls and average calls per hour data for FY 2020, FY 2021 and FY 2022 as of May 2022;
- Analyzed actual employees per shift for January 2022 to May 2022 to determine if minimum staffing levels were met;
- Reviewed the Schedule to understand shift assignment and how many employees were scheduled per shift;
- Reviewed the alternate schedule analysis performed by DECC staff in 2020;
- Documented steps taken to address the staffing shortages;
- Reviewed the bonus plan structure put in place for retention;
- Obtained vacancy statistics for the past 3 years and analyzed the data;
- Reviewed the training academies held in the last two years and the number of employees that were trained;
- Reviewed any process changes that were made to address staffing issues;
- Reviewed recruiting efforts by DECC;
- Reviewed the training program;
- Interviewed employees that had recently passed the training program;
- Reviewed exit survey for employees that left DECC;
- Reviewed the shift staff assignment process;
- Obtained a list of all current employees;
- Reviewed the shift schedule for a 2-month period to verify assignments; and
- Reviewed calls answered per employee.

During this engagement, the Audit Services Department staff also maintained awareness for the potential existence of fraud.

Compliance

Audit Services staff conducted this performance audit per generally accepted government auditing standards. Those standards require that the Audit Services staff plan and perform the audit to obtain sufficient and appropriate evidence to provide a reasonable basis for our findings and conclusions based on the audit objectives. Audit Services staff believe that the evidence obtained provides a reasonable basis for our findings and conclusions based on our audit objectives.

REPORT AT A GLANCE

Objective	Finding	Recommendation	Department Response	Implementation Date
Determine if DECC is meeting its goal to provide timely emergency call processing	F1: DECC has improved 911 call answering times since the start of FY 2022.	R1: The DECC should continue its efforts to ensure that the performance measures around 911 answer times are met. Value Added: <u>Risk Reduction</u> , <u>Efficiency</u>	Management concurs.	July 1, 2022
Review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain adequate staffing levels	F2: The turnover rate is high.	R2: The DECC Department staff should, in collaboration with the Human Resources staff, work to reduce turnover rates. DECC staff should perform root cause analysis and address issues identified if feasible. The DECC Department staff should also perform internal studies (surveys, focus groups) to understand why employees choose to stay. Value Added: <u>Risk Reduction</u> , <u>Efficiency</u>	Management concurs.	July 1, 2022
Review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain adequate staffing levels	F2: The turnover rate is high.	R3: The Human Resources Department staff should make exit surveys mandatory for employees that separate from DECC. Data from exit interviews should be shared with DECC staff to understand the reasons for separation. Value Added: <u>Risk Reduction</u> , <u>Efficiency</u>	Management concurs.	Immediately
Review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain	F3. Minimum staffing levels per shift were not derived using a	R4: The DECC should utilize a staffing model used by the industry to establish minimum staffing levels and work towards staffing to the established levels. In addition,	Management concurs with reservations.	July 1, 2022

Objective	Finding	Recommendation	Department Response	Implementation Date
adequate staffing levels	systematic formula.	they should continually monitor the adequacy of the staffing levels. Value Added: <u>Risk Reduction;</u> <u>Efficiency</u>		
Review steps undertaken by DECC to achieve and maintain adequate staffing levels	F4. The shift schedule was last reviewed in 2020; however, no changes were implemented.	R5: The DECC staff should revisit the possibility of alternate staffing schedules to see if better efficacy can be achieved. Value Added: <u>Risk Reduction;</u> <u>Efficiency</u>	Management concurs.	Q2 FY 2023
Review the training program	F5. Risk exists that recent turnover in trainers may affect DECC's training efforts. DECC has established a plan to mitigate this risk.	R6: The DECC staff should continue their efforts to ensure sufficient trainers are onboard to implement their training plan. They should reexamine the organization structure of the Training Division to make the Division more efficient and effective. Value Added: <u>Risk Reduction;</u> <u>Efficiency</u>	Management concurs.	July 1, 2022

AUDIT SERVICES DEPARTMENT

The Audit Services Department serves a three-fold role at the City of Durham. Our number one goal is to provide independent, objective assurance that City processes are working effectively. Secondly, we serve as internal fraud examiners when fraud, waste, or abuse is alleged against a City employee or department. Finally, to constantly foster high ethical standards, we provide in-depth ethical training to all City employees on a rolling basis. To learn more, visit our CODI site or our page on the [City of Durham's website](#).



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Audit Services Oversight Committee (ASOC)

To maintain its organizational independence, the Audit Services Department reports to the Audit Services Oversight Committee (ASOC) at a minimum of four times a year. The ASOC approves all proposed audit plans and completed audits prepared by Audit Services staff.

The Audit Services Oversight Committee is made up of six members: two City Council Members, three resident members, and one alternate City Council Member. The current members include one certified public accountant and persons with business experience. The City Manager is an ex-officio, non-voting member of the ASOC.

Audit Services Oversight Committee Members

Chair: Nick Long
Resident Member

Vice-Chair: Shanell Frazer
Resident Member

Committee Members:

Elaine O'Neal
Mayor
City Council Member

Jillian Johnson
City Council Member

Matthew Ruterbories
Resident Member

DeDreana Freeman
Alternate
City Council Member

Non-Voting Member:
Wanda S. Page
City Manager

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